country overseas, Nancy was among the hardest-working of all our first ladies. That this was known and appreciated by many Americans was evident from the thousands of letters we received praising Nancy. But I never understood or got used to the sniping at her, which at times got so bad that she was in tears when I came upstairs at the end of the day.

Here I was the president, and I was unable to stop my own wife from being hurt. It was hard for me to accept that she had to suffer simply because she was married to me. My attitude—and sometimes I'd express it—was: Dammit, you want to pick on someone, pick on me, not her. I'm in this job, not her. Even when Nancy tried to straighten out things with the facts, it often didn't do any good.

During the eight years we lived in the White House, it became a real *home* because Nancy worked to make it that way. I never stopped missing California; I've often said that a Californian (even one transplanted from the Midwest like me) who has to live someplace else lives in a perpetual state of homesickness. California, I like to say, isn't a place, it's a way of life. I once told Margaret Thatcher that her people should have crossed the other ocean to get to this continent; that way the capital of the United States would have been in California. But Nancy made the White House into a wonderful home for us, furnishing it with our things from home, and I felt very comfortable there—it was home. After the drab second-floor Central Hall was restored, we seldom closed the doors opening out from our living room, and the hall became an extension of it. As I sat looking across to the other side of the building, I never failed to remark to myself how magnificent it was.

Nancy wanted to make the state dinners we had at the White House more relaxed, as if guests were attending a dinner party at home. She worked hard to choose an interesting variety of guests, inviting people from the academic world, sports, business, entertainment, and other